A Tiger in the Zoo

The big idea

A Tiger in the Zoo by **Leslie Norris** contrasts the life of a tiger locked in a zoo cage with the free life he should be living in the forest. It is a powerful poem about **freedom versus captivity**.

Stanza by stanza

1. **In the cage:** The tiger **stalks** a few steps of his cage, his vivid stripes visible, his pads making **"quiet"** steps. He is full of **quiet rage**.
2. **Where he should be:** He should be **lurking in the shadow**, sliding through **long grass** near the **water hole**, where plump **deer** pass — hunting naturally.
3. **His power in the wild:** He should be **snarling** around houses at the jungle's edge, baring his white fangs and claws, **terrorising the village**.
4. **Reality:** But he is **locked in a concrete cell**, his strength behind bars, stalking the length of his cage and **ignoring visitors**.
5. **At night:** He hears the last voice at night, the **patrolling cars**, and stares with his brilliant eyes at the **brilliant stars** — longing for freedom.

STRUCTURE BASED ON CONTRAST

Stanzas 1, 4 and 5 = **captivity** (cage, concrete cell, bars). Stanzas 2 and 3 = **freedom in the wild** (shadow, long grass, water hole, jungle).

Poetic devices

- **Rhyme scheme: abcb** in each stanza — only lines 2 and 4 rhyme (for example, cage/rage in stanza 1).

- **Alliteration:** "**s**liding through long grass"; "**b**rilliant eyes ... **b**rilliant stars"; "**q**uiet rage".
- **Transferred epithet:** "**quiet rage**" — rage is shown as quiet because he is helpless; "**velvet quiet**" — softness of pads transferred to the quiet.
- **Oxymoron/contrast:** "quiet rage".
- **Enjambment:** lines run into each other, especially in stanza 2.
- **Imagery:** vivid visual images of the jungle and the cage.
- **Repetition:** "brilliant" eyes and stars.
- **Personification** of the tiger as having human feelings of rage and longing.

THE TIGER IS NOT HAPPY OR TAMED

He "ignores visitors" — this shows anger and indifference, not contentment.

Theme and message

- Wild animals belong in the wild; caging them denies their nature.
- Zoos may protect animals, but they take away freedom and dignity.
- The poem raises awareness about **wildlife conservation** in natural habitats.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Contrast the tiger's life in the zoo and in the forest. Why does the tiger ignore visitors? Why does he stare at the stars? Give two examples of alliteration and one transferred epithet. Should animals be kept in zoos? (Give a balanced opinion.)

Quick recap

- Leslie Norris; five stanzas; abcb.
- Cage: stalking, quiet rage, concrete cell, ignoring visitors, staring at stars.
- Wild: lurking in shadow, long grass, water hole, deer, terrorising villages.

- Theme: freedom vs captivity.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "A Tiger in the Zoo"?
   (a) Robert Frost (b) Carolyn Wells (c) Leslie Norris (d) Ogden Nash
2. Where, according to the poet, should the tiger be?
   (a) In a circus (b) In a bigger cage (c) Lurking in the shadow near the water hole (d) In a museum
3. "Quiet rage" is an example of
   (a) simile (b) transferred epithet / oxymoron (c) onomatopoeia (d) metaphor of light
4. Why does the tiger ignore the visitors?
   (a) He is sleeping (b) He is angry and helpless in captivity (c) He likes them (d) He cannot see them
5. What does the tiger stare at during the night?
   (a) The keeper (b) The moon (c) The houses (d) The brilliant stars
6. The rhyme scheme of each stanza is
   (a) aabb (b) abab (c) abcb (d) abba
7. Compare and contrast the tiger's life in the zoo with the life he would lead in the wild.

Answers: 1. c 2. c 3. b 4. b 5. d 6. c 7. see notes